

Americas Energy & Transition

Americas Integrated 2Q26: On the abuse of the word windfall



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The concept of a windfall gain arose in medieval Europe. A peasant sneaking onto an orchard to chop down trees for firewood could rightfully be labelled a thief and perhaps punished accordingly. However, a gust of wind knocking off a branch creates a free source of fuel and no obvious crime - a windfall gain ("value received unexpectedly from good fortune rather than effort, intelligence, or the venturing of capital").

In risk-taking businesses one should expect variations in returns over time. Imagine running a portfolio of equities where strong performers are declared windfalls and arbitrarily excessively taxed despite the effort & intelligence of deploying capital amidst risk.

In that same vein, integrated oil companies are price-takers that deploy tens of billions of dollars of capital a year into complex global projects levered to volatile cyclical commodity prices buffeted by geopolitics. These companies deploy capital expecting to earn returns on capital through the cycle measured in the teens. Basic math and logic dictates that returns and earnings will be volatile and occasionally extremely strong.

2Q26 was just such a strong quarter, with CVX results outpacing XOM. CVX beat both EPS and revenue by 7.3% and 3.1%, respectively, while XOM beat revenue by 12.5%, but missed EPS by 0.5%. Part of XOM's relative miss we attribute to scheduled refinery maintenance. While it is useful to make hay while the sun shines, crows come home to roost when maintenance is excessively deferred.

Nevertheless, both companies delivered muted responses around such strong results. Cash return to shareholders was strong but fairly flat with share buybacks creeping up and a preference for building cash and reducing debt. We suspect subtlety in the strategy to avoid the ire of regulators and naysayers. Nonetheless, the cash flow is real and accumulating and will almost certainly do so for this quarter as well (given we are one month in and the fact that the September Brent contract is trading near \$90/bbl). And perhaps further quarters as the Hormuz Quagmire continues.

Given the extremely strong refining margins and XOM's heavier weighting to downstream compared with CVX's heavier weighting to upstream, we have a preference for XOM, despite their greater production volume exposed to the Strait's closure.

To some degree part of the investment thesis for both ExxonMobil and Chevron is that while ongoing conflicts (US-Iran and Russia-Ukraine) must eventually end, there aren't obvious palatable ways for them to end especially in an era of asymmetric drone warfare. As the conflicts drag on, risks of oil disruptions (and super spikes) rise encouraging investors to be overweight integrations. Of course some day the conflict will end and oil prices (and refined prices) will slowly normalize and in such a backdrop it's hard to imagine stunning outperformance from the integrations. For now, the timing of that thief in the night seems further rather than closer.

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BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	Cur	31 Jul 2026	Price Target	TTM Rel. Perf.	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
			Closing Price			Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
XOM (ExxonMobil)	O	USD	155.44	182.00	21.1%	USD	7.37	16.08	14.46	21.1	9.7	10.7
OLD								16.37	14.49			
CVX (Chevron)	M	USD	196.83	209.00	11.7%	USD	6.42	16.97	13.59	30.6	11.6	14.5
OLD				204.00				16.58	13.26			
SPX			7,489.72									

PRICE TARGET CHANGE / ESTIMATE CHANGE IN BOLD

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We reiterate XOM Outperform. We reiterate CVX Market-Perform, increasing our target price to \$209/sh, as we increase total production by 60 kbopd from debottleneckings at TCO.

DETAILS

INTEGRATED OIL UPDATE: FULL YEAR GUIDANCE UNCHANGED DESPITE THE WAR

XOM delivered 12.5% higher revenue vs consensus but EPS that was roughly 0.52% lower than consensus of \$3.54/sh. The shares closed down ~1% (while XOP, the E&P index, increased 1.4%). Darren talked about the apparent lack of refining capacity in the market, and expectations for a robust refining market with high margins that will continue. Full year guidance remained largely the same, with FY26 upstream production guidance still at 4.9 mboepd, capex still at \$27-29B, and share buybacks still at \$20B for 2026. XOM highlighted the use of stronger free cashflow this quarter for drawing down net debt, with net debt down in 2Q26 by \$7B.

CVX reported 1Q26 adjusted EPS of \$6.06, beating consensus by 7.33%, with shares up~ 2.35% at the close while XOP stayed rose 1.4%. The company used this quarter to pay down debt, reducing total debt by \$8.4B in 2Q26 and \$3.76B YTD. CVX also highlighted its successful debottlenecking of the third generation plant at TCO, increasing nameplate capacity by +60,000 barrels/day. CVX also guided to the lower end of its FY 2026 capex range of \$18-19B, as well as Permian capex, where CVX now expects it to be lower than \$3.5B due to improvements in drilling efficiencies and completion efficiencies. Production increased 5% Q-o-Q with CVX reiterating capital discipline and strong execution. Buybacks guidance remained unchanged at \$2.5-3B per quarter.

APPENDIX - FINANCIAL FORECASTS

EXHIBIT 1: Income Statement - XOM

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E
Upstream Growth %	0.7%	0.0%	15.9%	9.3%	-2.9%	11.2%	3.9%	3.4%	3.0%
% Liquids	63%	66%	69%	70%	68%	70%	70%	70%	70%
Total Oil (kbopd)	2,037	2,104	2,502	2,795	2,566	2,953	3,061	3,153	3,240
Realized Oil Price	\$ 92.43	\$ 73.14	\$ 77.81	\$ 63.00	\$ 84.19	\$ 72.68	\$ 69.60	\$ 69.49	\$ 69.37
Total NGL (kbopd)	317	345	483	534	582	627	667	704	738
Realized NGL Price	\$ 43.29	\$ 29.01	\$ 27.59	\$ 25.43	\$ 33.67	\$ 28.96	\$ 27.67	\$ 27.55	\$ 27.46
Total Gas (mmcf)	8,295	7,734	8,078	8,441	8,705	9,207	9,524	9,826	10,106
Realized Gas Price	\$ 9.85	\$ 6.05	\$ 5.03	\$ 4.49	\$ 6.14	\$ 5.51	\$ 5.17	\$ 5.13	\$ 5.10
Total Volume (kboepd)	3,737	3,738	4,331	4,736	4,600	5,114	5,315	5,495	5,662
Reported Price (\$/boe) ex mark to market	\$ 75.94	\$ 56.36	\$ 57.40	\$ 48.06	\$ 62.86	\$ 55.42	\$ 52.81	\$ 52.58	\$ 52.37
Daily Refinery Throughput (kbopd)	4,040	4,052	3,919	3,989	3,952	3,952	3,952	3,952	3,952
Refinery Utilization %	88%	89%	91%	92%	91%	91%	91%	91%	91%
Chemicals & Spec. Product Sales (Mtpa)	27.0	27.0	27.1	29.1	29.1	29.7	30.0	30.2	30.5
% of Chemical Capacity	103%	102%	102%	101%	101%	103%	104%	105%	106%
Downstream Margin (\$/boe produced)	\$ 48.51	\$ 47.47	\$ 31.02	\$ 32.74	\$ 47.88	\$ 43.41	\$ 41.94	\$ 40.73	\$ 39.69
Revenue (ex mark to market)	169,716	141,668	139,793	139,657	185,927	184,499	183,814	187,155	190,253
Operating Costs	(42,609)	(36,885)	(39,609)	(42,424)	(39,968)	(43,107)	(43,901)	(44,485)	(44,917)
DD&A Recurring (incl. impairments)	(24,040)	(20,641)	(23,442)	(25,993)	(25,246)	(28,070)	(29,171)	(30,162)	(31,076)
Exploration Expense	(1,025)	(751)	(826)	(1,007)	(805)	(875)	(887)	(895)	(900)
Clean EBIT	63,546	43,747	39,531	33,538	80,476	68,340	64,446	65,031	65,693
Other EBIT	3,542	3,500	4,144	3,269	4,834	4,834	4,834	4,834	4,834
SG&A	10,095	9,919	9,976	11,128	10,051	10,506	10,489	10,477	10,468
Combined EBIT	80,905	56,542	50,113	43,838	90,374	78,238	74,344	74,929	75,591
Net Interest	(798)	(849)	(996)	(603)	(595)	(580)	(566)	(548)	(509)
Minority Interest	(1,837)	(1,344)	(1,383)	(920)	(920)	(920)	(920)	(920)	(920)
Pretax income	80,107	55,693	49,117	43,235	89,779	77,657	73,778	74,381	75,082
Reported Tax	(20,176)	(15,429)	(13,810)	(11,504)	(23,888)	(20,663)	(19,631)	(19,791)	(19,978)
One-Time Tax Impact Increase/(Decrease)	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Tax Rate (%)	25%	28%	28%	27%	27%	27%	27%	27%	27%
Clean NI	59,931	40,264	35,307	31,731	65,891	56,994	54,147	54,590	55,104
Reported NI	55,740	36,010	33,680	28,844	64,971	56,074	53,227	53,670	54,184
Clean EPS (\$)	14.25	9.94	8.21	7.37	16.08	14.46	14.27	14.93	15.62
Reported EPS(\$)	13.26	8.89	7.84	6.70	15.86	14.23	14.03	14.68	15.36

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 2: Balance Sheet - XOM

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E
Current Assets	97,631	96,609	91,990	83,382	106,860	106,135	105,788	107,483	109,055
Current Liabilities	68,411	61,226	65,352	63,034	66,518	69,695	69,305	68,744	70,191
Net Working Capital	29,220	35,383	26,638	20,348	40,342	36,440	36,483	38,740	38,864
Property, Plant & Equipment	204,692	214,940	294,318	299,373	299,098	297,918	296,096	293,636	290,541
Investments and Advances	49,793	47,630	47,200	45,317	40,279	35,241	30,204	25,166	20,128
Other Assets (includes assoc.)	16,951	17,138	19,967	20,908	20,908	20,908	20,908	20,908	20,908
Total Operating Capital	300,656	315,091	388,123	385,946	400,627	390,507	383,690	378,449	370,442
Excess Cash	0	0	0	0	19,608	54,850	83,803	111,374	139,813
Total Capital Employed	300,656	315,091	388,123	385,946	420,235	445,358	467,494	489,824	510,255
Sources of Capital									
Short-Term Debt	634	4,090	4,955	9,296	10,173	10,173	10,173	10,173	10,173
Long-Term Debt & Capital Leases	40,559	37,483	36,755	34,241	32,229	31,229	30,129	28,629	24,579
Deferred Income Taxes	22,874	24,452	39,042	40,216	44,428	48,071	51,532	55,021	58,543
Other Liabilities	34,116	36,528	36,765	35,567	35,567	35,567	35,567	35,567	35,567
Total Non-Equity Capital	98,183	102,553	117,517	119,320	122,397	125,040	127,401	129,390	128,862
Total Equity Capital	202,473	212,538	270,606	266,626	297,838	320,318	340,093	360,434	381,393
Total Assets	369,067	376,317	453,475	448,980	486,753	515,053	536,799	558,567	580,446
Total Sources of Capital	300,656	315,091	388,123	385,946	420,235	445,358	467,494	489,824	510,255

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 3: Cash Flow Statement - XOM

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E
Operating									
Net Income	55,740	36,010	33,680	28,844	64,971	56,074	53,227	53,670	54,184
Depr., Depl. & Amort.(basic)	24,040	20,641	23,442	25,993	25,246	28,070	29,171	30,162	31,076
Asset retirement obligation	(1,932)	(2,000)	(2,100)	(2,205)	(2,315)	(2,431)	(2,553)	(2,680)	(2,814)
Dry Hole	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Non-cash Incentive Compensation	(2,981)	1,000	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Deferred Tax	3,758	2,613	2,304	2,028	4,212	3,643	3,461	3,489	3,522
Other	(1,634)	1,360	(478)	5,038	5,038	5,038	5,038	5,038	5,038
Net Trade (Delta WC)	(194)	(4,255)	(1,826)	(7,728)	(19,994)	3,902	(43)	(2,257)	(125)
Total Operating	76,797	55,369	55,022	51,970	77,156	94,297	88,302	87,422	90,881
Investing									
Capital Expenditures	18,407	21,919	24,306	28,358	26,655	28,459	28,797	29,022	29,167
Acquisitions	3,090	2,995	3,299	4,133	0	0	0	0	0
Sales	(5,247)	(4,078)	(4,987)	(3,158)	(4,000)	(4,000)	(4,000)	(4,000)	(4,000)
Other	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Dividends to Minority Shareholders & FX	(1,508)	(1,562)	(2,680)	(3,406)	(3,406)	(3,406)	(3,406)	(3,406)	(3,406)
Total Investing	14,742	19,274	19,938	25,927	19,249	21,053	21,391	21,616	21,761
Less: Dividends	14,939	14,941	16,704	17,231	16,891	16,728	16,585	16,462	16,358
Net Funds (After Div.)	47,116	21,154	18,380	8,812	41,016	56,515	50,326	49,344	52,762
Financing									
Debt Issued/(Repurchased)	(3,644)	290	(4,341)	(3,752)	(1,135)	(1,000)	(1,100)	(1,500)	(4,050)
Other	(5,454)	(1,793)	(2,791)	2,707	0	0	0	0	0
Equity Issued/(Repurchased)	(15,155)	(17,748)	(19,629)	(20,273)	(20,273)	(20,273)	(20,273)	(20,273)	(20,273)
Total Financing	(24,253)	(19,251)	(26,761)	(21,318)	(21,408)	(21,273)	(21,373)	(21,773)	(24,323)
Net Increase (Decrease) in Cash	22,863	1,903	(8,381)	(12,506)	19,608	35,242	28,953	27,571	28,439

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 4: Income Statement - CVX

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E
Upstream Growth %	-3.2%	4.1%	7.0%	11.5%	8.9%	3.1%	0.6%	0.7%	3.2%
% Liquids	57%	59%	59%	62%	64%	64%	65%	65%	65%
Total Oil (kbopd)	1,440	1,507	1,560	1,827	2,093	2,144	2,175	2,199	2,324
Realized Oil Price	\$ 91.51	\$ 78.99	\$ 73.21	\$ 63.62	\$ 85.77	\$ 73.85	\$ 70.91	\$ 70.95	\$ 71.16
Total NGL (kbopd)	279	323	415	477	505	543	540	537	534
Realized NGL Price	\$ 34.53	\$ 18.29	\$ 23.36	\$ 22.80	\$ 34.89	\$ 30.07	\$ 28.87	\$ 28.86	\$ 28.85
Total Gas (mmcf)	7,677	7,744	8,178	8,515	8,729	8,938	8,921	8,978	9,047
Realized Gas Price	\$ 9.90	\$ 6.05	\$ 5.49	\$ 5.44	\$ 7.16	\$ 6.60	\$ 6.44	\$ 6.46	\$ 6.49
Total Volume (kboepd)	2,999	3,121	3,338	3,723	4,053	4,178	4,202	4,233	4,367
Reported Price (\$/boe) ex mark to market	\$ 72.50	\$ 55.05	\$ 50.56	\$ 46.58	\$ 64.07	\$ 55.93	\$ 54.08	\$ 54.24	\$ 54.87
Daily Refinery Throughput (kbopd)	1,505	1,559	1,526	1,690	1,711	1,748	1,786	1,823	1,860
Refinery Utilization %	85%	88%	86%	93%	92%	92%	92%	92%	92%
Downstream Margin (\$/boe produced)	\$ 10.00	\$ 13.19	\$ 10.35	\$ 9.51	\$ 11.41	\$ 9.51	\$ 9.51	\$ 9.51	\$ 9.51
Revenue (ex mark to market)	90,301	77,717	74,208	76,218	111,653	99,783	97,526	98,481	102,597
Operating Costs	(28,746)	(29,107)	(32,180)	(33,235)	(35,264)	(34,529)	(32,996)	(31,575)	(30,945)
DD&A Recurring (incl. impairments)	(16,319)	(17,326)	(17,282)	(20,132)	(22,354)	(23,501)	(24,113)	(24,774)	(26,069)
Exploration Expense	(974)	(914)	(995)	(1,051)	0	0	0	0	0
Clean EBIT	39,950	26,229	18,917	16,674	49,061	36,782	35,447	37,163	40,618
Other EBIT	1,950	(1,095)	4,782	1,599	(3,800)	(3,800)	(3,800)	(3,800)	(3,800)
SG&A	4,312	4,141	4,834	5,126	4,975	4,970	4,970	4,970	4,965
Combined EBIT	52,087	32,504	26,155	20,396	52,261	39,982	38,647	40,363	43,818
Net Interest	(516)	(469)	(594)	(1,217)	(993)	(889)	(883)	(883)	(883)
Minority Interest	(143)	(42)	(88)	(186)	(186)	(186)	(186)	(186)	(186)
Pretax Income	51,571	32,035	25,561	19,179	51,267	39,093	37,764	39,480	42,935
Reported Tax	(14,066)	(8,173)	(9,757)	(7,258)	(18,120)	(13,426)	(12,592)	(12,769)	(13,458)
One-Time Tax Impact Increase/(Decrease)	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Tax Rate (%)	27%	26%	38%	36%	35%	34%	33%	32%	31%
Clean NI	37,505	23,862	15,804	11,921	33,147	25,667	25,172	26,710	29,477
Reported NI	35,465	21,369	17,661	12,299	32,724	25,237	24,740	26,277	29,036
Clean EPS (\$)	19.33	12.69	8.70	6.42	16.97	13.59	13.77	15.08	17.15
Reported EPS(\$)	18.28	11.36	9.72	6.63	16.75	13.36	13.53	14.83	16.89

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 5: Balance Sheet - CVX

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E
Current Assets	50,343	41,128	40,911	38,552	47,406	42,842	41,974	42,341	43,923
Current Liabilities	32,244	31,729	34,152	32,410	37,577	35,965	34,912	34,281	34,553
Net Working Capital	18,099	9,399	6,759	6,142	9,829	6,877	7,062	8,060	9,370
Property, Plant & Equipment	143,591	153,619	147,799	219,729	211,784	199,996	188,246	179,007	169,075
Investments and Advances	45,238	46,812	47,438	43,867	43,867	43,867	43,867	43,867	43,867
Other Assets (includes assoc.)	18,537	20,073	20,790	21,864	21,864	21,864	21,864	21,864	21,864
Total Operating Capital	225,465	229,903	222,786	291,602	287,344	272,604	261,038	252,798	244,176
Excess Cash	0	0	0	0	8,943	23,359	34,306	43,291	55,302
Total Capital Employed	225,465	229,903	222,786	291,602	296,287	295,963	295,345	296,089	299,478
Sources of Capital									
Short-Term Debt	1,964	529	4,406	977	977	977	977	977	977
Long-Term Debt & Capital Leases	21,375	20,307	20,135	39,781	36,017	35,517	35,517	35,517	35,517
Deferred Income Taxes	17,131	18,830	19,137	30,014	32,421	34,256	36,029	37,882	39,898
Other Liabilities	24,753	28,308	25,951	28,654	28,654	28,654	28,654	28,654	28,654
Total Non-Equity Capital	65,223	67,974	69,629	99,426	98,069	99,404	101,177	103,030	105,046
Total Equity Capital	160,242	161,929	153,157	192,176	198,218	196,559	194,168	193,059	194,432
Total Assets	257,709	261,632	256,938	324,012	333,864	331,928	330,256	330,370	334,032
Total Sources of Capital	225,465	229,903	222,786	291,602	296,287	295,963	295,345	296,089	299,478

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 6: Cash Flow Statement - CVX

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E
Operating									
Net Income	35,465	21,369	17,661	12,485	32,724	25,237	24,740	26,277	29,036
Depr., Depl. & Amort.(basic)	16,319	17,326	17,282	20,132	22,354	23,501	24,113	24,774	26,069
Asset retirement obligation	(550)	(100)	(170)	(462)	(485)	(509)	(535)	(562)	(590)
Dry Hole	486	0	429	325	325	325	325	325	325
Non-cash Incentive Compensation	(1,322)	0	(1,250)	(588)	(588)	(588)	(588)	(588)	(588)
Deferred Tax	2,124	300	1,200	986	2,407	1,835	1,773	1,853	2,016
Other	(5,045)	(86)	(4,860)	(1,863)	0	0	0	0	0
Net Trade (Delta WC)	2,125	(3,200)	1,200	585	(7,751)	2,715	(230)	(979)	(1,228)
Total Operating	49,602	35,609	31,492	33,900	48,986	52,516	49,597	51,101	55,040
Investing									
Capital Expenditures	11,974	15,829	16,448	17,347	18,248	16,530	16,652	16,799	17,372
Acquisitions	2,862	(100)	0	1,056	0	0	0	0	0
Sales	(2,635)	(669)	(7,704)	1,826	(2,000)	(3,500)	(3,000)	0	0
Other	117	0	0	0	(2,000)	(1,500)	(1,500)	(1,500)	(1,500)
Dividends to Minority Shareholders & FX	(210)	172	192	(4,318)	0	0	0	0	0
Total Investing	12,108	15,232	8,936	15,911	14,248	11,530	12,152	15,299	15,872
Less: Dividends	10,968	11,300	11,800	12,751	14,094	14,309	14,543	14,798	15,075
Net Funds (After Div.)	26,526	9,077	10,756	5,238	20,643	26,678	22,902	21,004	24,093
Financing									
Debt Issued/(Repurchased)	(7,034)	(5,535)	2,099	(7,904)	(3,764)	(500)	0	0	0
Other	(1,749)	1,313	1,145	13,505	0	0	0	0	0
Equity Issued/(Repurchased)	(5,417)	(14,678)	(15,044)	(11,855)	(12,000)	(12,000)	(12,000)	(12,000)	(12,000)
Total Financing	(14,200)	(18,900)	(11,800)	(6,254)	(15,764)	(12,500)	(12,000)	(12,000)	(12,000)
Net Increase (Decrease) in Cash	12,326	(9,823)	(1,044)	(1,016)	4,879	14,178	10,902	9,004	12,093

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

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We rate XOM Outperform. We reach our target price of \$182/sh by applying an 7.0x multiple to 2027E EBITDA of \$96B and incorporating additional FCF to shareholders.

Chevron Corp

We rate CVX Market-Perform. We reach our target price of \$209/sh by applying a 6.5x multiple to 2027E EBITDA of \$60B and incorporating additional FCF to shareholders.

RISKS**Exxon Mobil Corp**

We rate XOM Outperform. Key downside risks to our price target include (a) market conditions yielding lower commodity prices than forecast, (b) failure to execute on critical growth initiatives (e.g. Stabroek, Permian, downstream/petrochemicals expansions), (c) lower refining margins than forecast, and (d) a prolonged polymer downcycle.

Chevron Corp

We rate CVX Market-Perform. Key downside risks to our price target include (a) market conditions yielding lower commodity prices than forecast, (b) failure to execute on critical growth initiatives (e.g. Permian, DJ, GoM, Tengiz), and (c) lower refining margins than forecast.

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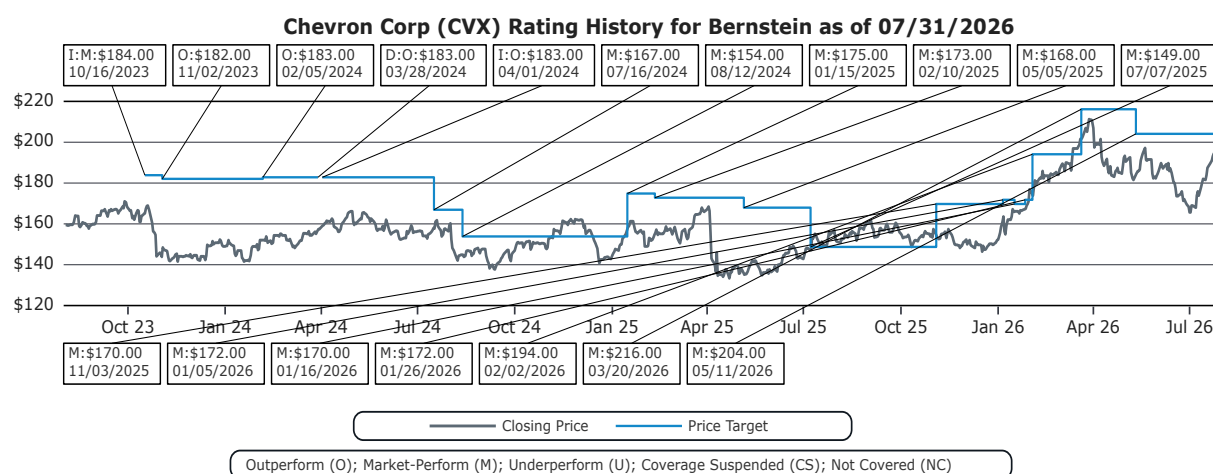
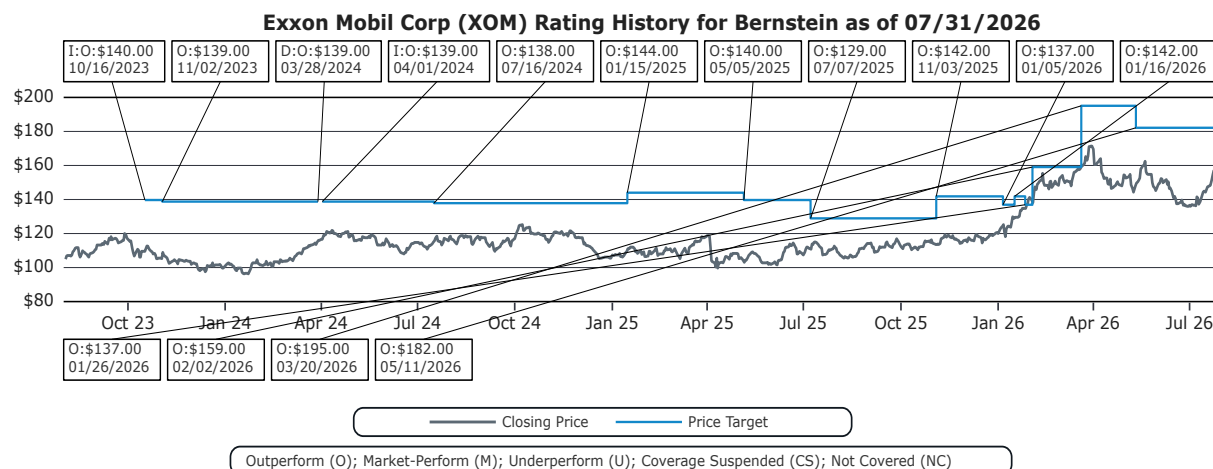
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